

Ask vs Act

The two modes Cowork runs in. Pick deliberately. Print this. Stick it next to the keyboard.

ASK

Cowork pauses before each step and waits for your approval. Slower, but you see everything.

When to use it

- You are new to Cowork or to a particular task type.
- Files matter and you cannot easily roll back changes.
- You are using a connector for the first time.
- The task touches more than a handful of files.
- You are not sitting in front of the screen the whole time.
- You are not sure. (Default to Ask whenever this applies.)

Examples

- Reorganising a folder with documents you actually care about.
- First time letting Cowork draft replies from your inbox.
- Bulk-renaming photos by date and event.
- Editing a long document where you want to see each change.

ACT

Cowork runs straight through and reports back at the end. Faster, but you cannot intervene mid-step.

When to use it

- You have done this exact task before and trust the pattern.
- The task is reversible. Worst case, you re-run it.
- You are actively watching and ready to hit stop.
- Files are throwaway, sandboxed, or backed up.
- Speed matters more than oversight for this task.

Examples

- Tidying a Downloads folder you have already had Cowork organise once.
- Pulling data from receipts into a spreadsheet (read-only on sources).
- Generating drafts of writing where you will edit afterwards anyway.
- Running a research task that only writes to one output file.

Three ground rules for both modes

- Cowork will always ask before permanently deleting, regardless of mode.
- You can switch modes mid-session. If Act starts feeling risky, switch to Ask.
- If something looks wrong, hit stop. Do not argue with a running task.

When in doubt, default to ASK.